

Opening VS Code From The Terminal Via Code

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Today I Learned added on 2025-11-30, learned on 2025-11-30; edited on 2026-06-14.

For my paid and unpaid programming work I've used [VS Code](#). The following has been routine for me for roughly 4 years: I open the target folder by pressing the **Open** button on VS Code's platform or, if I remember to, to **Cmd+O** on my MacOS to open a folder.

Today, I remarked internally to myself that VS Code probably has a method to open a new window from within the Terminal. Lo and behold, it does: `code .` to open the current directory in VS Code.

Of note, to get the `code` command working, I performed the following actions:

1. Open VS Code.
2. Open Command Palette via **Cmd+Shift+P**.
3. Type: "shell command"
4. Select: "Shell Command: Install 'code' command in PATH"
5. Gave permissions to VS Code.

Running `code --help` shows some other interesting options:

```
code --help
Visual Studio Code 1.105.1
```

```
Usage: code [options] [paths...]
```

To read from stdin, append '-' (e.g. `'ps aux | grep code | code -'`)

Options

<code>-d --diff <file> <file></code>	Compare two files with each other.
<code>-m --merge <path1> <path2> <base> <result></code>	Perform a three-way merge by providing paths for each file, the common origin of both modified versions, and the merge results.
<code>-a --add <folder></code>	Add folder(s) to the last active window.
<code>--remove <folder></code>	Remove folder(s) from the last active window.
<code>-g --goto <file:line[:character]></code>	Open a file at the path on the specified line and character.
<code>-n --new-window</code>	Force to open a new window.
<code>-r --reuse-window</code>	Force to open a file or folder in an already open window.
<code>-w --wait</code>	Wait for the files to be closed before returning.
<code>--locale <locale></code>	The locale to use (e.g. en-US or zh-TW).
<code>--user-data-dir <dir></code>	Specifies the directory that user data is kept for multiple distinct instances of Code.
<code>--profile <profileName></code>	Opens the provided folder or workspace with the specified profile. If the profile does not exist, a new one is created.

<code>-h --help</code>	Print usage.
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Extensions Management

<code>--extensions-dir <dir></code>	Set the root path for extensions.
<code>--list-extensions</code>	List the installed extensions.
<code>--show-versions</code>	Show versions of installed extensions, when using <code>--list-extensions</code> .
<code>--category <category></code>	Filters installed extensions by provided category, when using <code>--list-extensions</code> .
<code>--install-extension <ext-id path></code>	Installs or updates an extension. The argument is either a path to a VSIX or an extension identifier. The identifier of an extension is ' <code>{publisher}.{name}@{version}</code> '. For example: ' <code>vscode.csharp@1.2.3</code> '. To install a specific version, use ' <code>{publisher}.{name}@{version}</code> '. To update to latest version, use ' <code>{publisher}.{name}</code> '.
<code>--force</code>	Force install the extension, even if it is already installed.
<code>--pre-release</code>	Installs the pre-release version of the extension, when using <code>--install-extension</code> .
<code>--uninstall-extension <ext-id></code>	Uninstalls an extension.
<code>--update-extensions</code>	Update the installed extensions.
<code>--enable-proposed-api <ext-id></code>	Enables proposed API features for extensions. Can receive multiple arguments to enable individually.

Model Context Protocol

<code>--add-mcp <json></code>	Adds a Model Context Protocol server definition to the user profile. Accepts a JSON string, for example: ' <code>{"name": "server-name", "command": "..."}'</code> '
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Troubleshooting

<code>-v --version</code>	Print version.
<code>--verbose</code>	Print verbose output (implies <code>--log <level></code>).
<code>--log <level></code>	Log level to use. Default is 'info'. Allowed values are 'warn', 'info', 'debug', 'trace', 'off'. You can add log entries for an extension by passing extension id and log level, for example: ' <code>{publisher}.{name}:{logLevel}</code> '. For example: ' <code>ms-vscode.csharp:debug</code> '. You can receive one or more such entries.
<code>-s --status</code>	Print process usage and diagnostics information.
<code>--prof-startup</code>	Run CPU profiler during startup.
<code>--disable-extensions</code>	Disable all installed extensions. This option is only when the command opens a new window.
<code>--disable-extension <ext-id></code>	Disable the provided extension. This option is only when the command opens a new window.
<code>--sync <on off></code>	Turn sync on or off.
<code>--inspect-extensions <port></code>	Allow debugging and profiling of extensions. Check the connection URI.
<code>--inspect-brk-extensions <port></code>	Allow debugging and profiling of extensions with a breakpoint after start. Check the developer tools for the connection URI.
<code>--disable-lcd-text</code>	Disable LCD font rendering.
<code>--disable-gpu</code>	Disable GPU hardware acceleration.
<code>--disable-chromium-sandbox</code>	Use this option only when there is requirement to run as root user on Linux or when running as an elevated user on Windows.
<code>--locate-shell-integration-path <shell></code>	Print the path to a terminal shell integration script.

	'bash', 'pwsh', 'zsh' or 'fish'.
--telemetry	Shows all telemetry events which VS code collects
--transient	Run with temporary data and extension directories time.

Subcommands

chat	Pass in a prompt to run in a chat session in the current working directory.
serve-web	Run a server that displays the editor UI in browsers.
tunnel	Make the current machine accessible from vscode.dev or other machines through